

Primary Source Reading 1: The Greatest Happiness Principle

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From John Stuart Mill, Utilitarianism, Chapter II (1863) — text unaltered Read before Lesson 13a: What Is Utilitarianism?

Before you read: Mill opens Chapter II by stating his theory plainly, then immediately turns to answer its oldest and most dismissive objection: that a morality built on pleasure is “worthy only of swine.” As you read, watch how Mill tries to rescue the theory not by abandoning pleasure as the standard, but by arguing that pleasures themselves come in different kinds — some higher than others.

The Greatest Happiness Principle

The creed which accepts as the foundation of morals, Utility, or the Greatest Happiness Principle, holds that actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness, wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness. By happiness is intended pleasure, and the absence of pain; by unhappiness, pain, and the privation of pleasure.

A Doctrine Worthy Only of Swine?

Now, such a theory of life excites in many minds, and among them in some of the most estimable in feeling and purpose, inveterate dislike. To suppose that life has (as they express it) no higher end than pleasure — no better and nobler object of desire and pursuit — they designate as utterly mean and grovelling; as a doctrine worthy only of swine, to whom the followers of Epicurus were, at a very early period, contemptuously likened.

Higher and Lower Pleasures

If I am asked what I mean by difference of quality in pleasures... I answer, that of two pleasures, if there be one to which all or almost all who have experience of both give a decided preference, irrespective of any feeling of moral obligation to prefer it, that is the more desirable pleasure.

Now it is an unquestionable fact that those who are equally acquainted with, and equally capable of appreciating and enjoying, both, do give a most marked preference to the manner of existence which employs their higher faculties. Few human creatures would consent to be changed into any of the lower animals, for a promise of the fullest allowance of a beast's pleasures; no intelligent human being would consent to be a fool, no instructed person would be an ignoramus, no person of feeling and conscience would be selfish and base, even though they should be persuaded that the fool, the dunce, or the rascal is better satisfied with his lot than they are with theirs.

Socrates Dissatisfied

Whoever supposes that this preference takes place at a sacrifice of happiness — that the superior being, in anything like equal circumstances, is not happier than the inferior — confounds the two very different ideas, of happiness, and content. It is indisputable that the being whose capacities of enjoyment are low, has the greatest chance of having them fully satisfied; and a highly endowed being will always feel that any happiness which he can look for, as the world is constituted, is imperfect. But he can learn to bear its imperfections, if they are at all bearable... It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied. And if the fool, or the pig, are of a different opinion, it is because they only know their own side of the question. The other party to the comparison knows both sides.

After you read: Notice the move Mill is making. He does not abandon pleasure as the standard of value — he insists some pleasures are qualitatively better than others, and that the people best positioned to judge (those who have experienced both) consistently prefer the higher kind. Ask yourself, as you move into the lesson, whether this rescues the theory from the “swine” objection or simply relocates the problem: who exactly counts as a competent judge, and what happens if their preferences turn out to reflect privilege rather than genuine insight?